

Calculate Short Lines

Compare forcing replies, keep a material count, and stop only when the position is stable.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 A check narrows the replies

P. 3

02 Compare the recaptures that really exist

P. 6

03 Look for a check before recapturing

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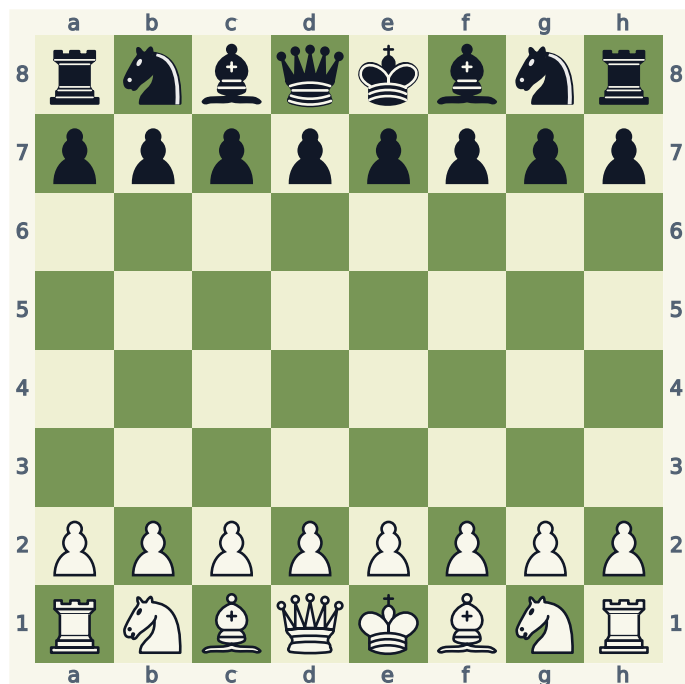
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

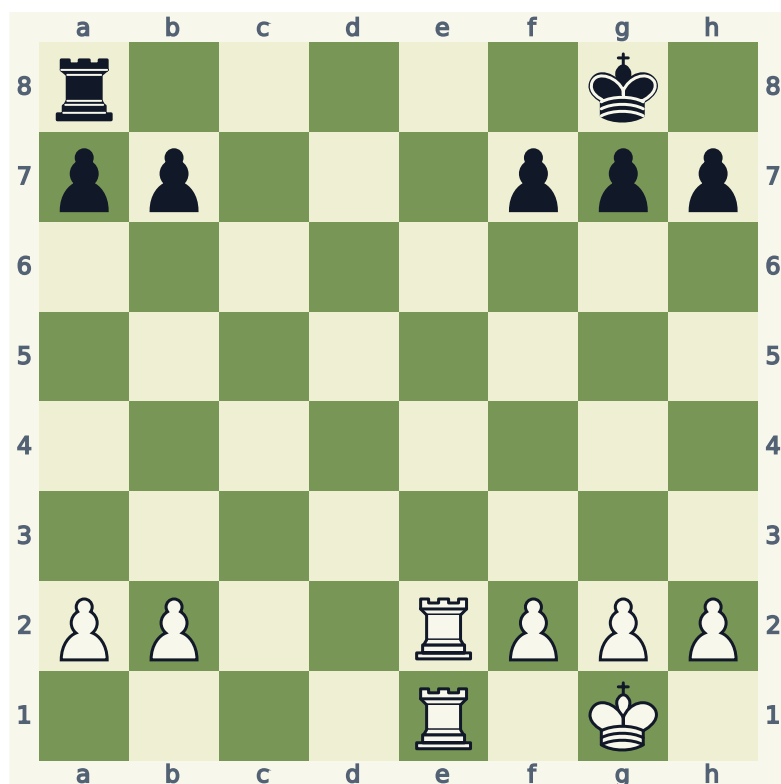
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

A check narrows the replies

Calculate a small tree accurately before trying a long line. At every check, test three responses: capture the checker, block the line, or move the king.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White has two rooks on the e-file. The rear rook on e1 supports the rook on e2.
2. Black's king has pawns on f7, g7 and h7, so it cannot escape to the seventh rank.
3. After Re8+, Black's rook on a8 can capture along the eighth rank.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Re8+ Rxe8 2. Rxe8#

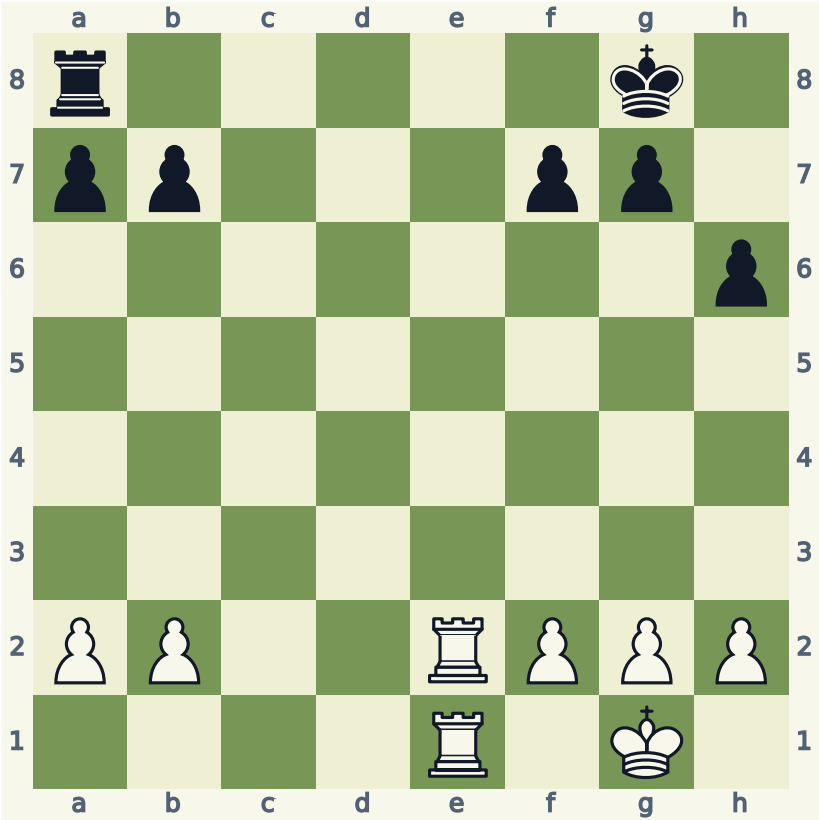
The rook on e2 plays Re8+. Black cannot run to f8 or h8 because the rook attacks those squares; its own pawns occupy the escape squares below. There is no interposition available. ...Rxe8 is the only legal reply.

Now the e1-rook follows with Rxe8#. Capturing the first checking rook removed Black's last defender. Stop and prove mate by checking every king destination, capture and block, rather than assuming the familiar back-rank pattern is enough.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. What new escape square has the h-pawn move created?
- 2. Play the same exchange on e8. Is the second rook capture checkmate?
- 3. What has White gained even if Black survives?

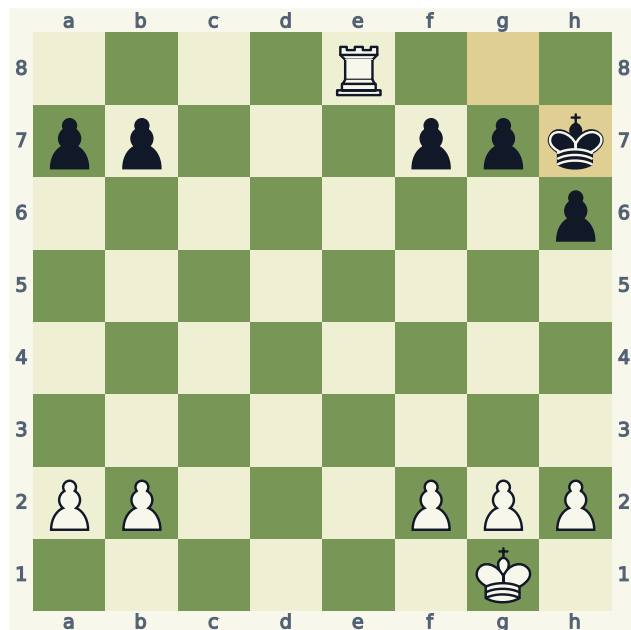
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): r5k1/pp3pp1/7p/8/8/PP2RPPP/4R1K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Re8+ Rxe8 2. Rxe8+ Kh7

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The pawn on h6 leaves h7 empty. Unlike the seventh-rank squares occupied by pawns in Model A, h7 can be a legal king destination.

2. Re8+ Rxe8 Rxe8+ is check, but Black has ...Kh7. The rook on e8 attacks the eighth rank, not h7. A plus sign is correct; a mate sign is not.

3. White began with two rooks against one and finishes with one rook against none. That is a winning material advantage in this simple position, but it still requires conversion. The calculation must report that result accurately instead of calling it mate.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

An identical-looking line may end in check instead of mate if one pawn has moved. Treat the final board as a new position and verify its legal moves.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

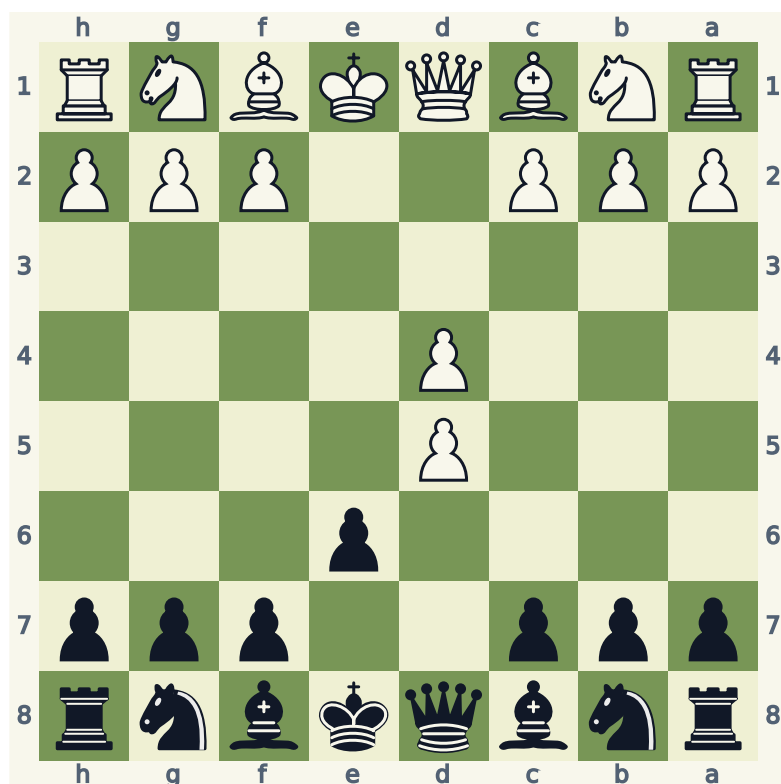
For three checking sequences from your games, set up the final position and list every legal reply. Mark where you stopped calculating too early.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Compare the recaptures that really exist

Before comparing moves, list only moves that are legal in the actual position. A recapture can restore material yet cost time if it exposes the queen to development with an attack.

MODEL A / BLACK TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's pawn on d5 has just captured Black's d-pawn.
2. Black's e6-pawn can capture diagonally to d5.
3. The queen on d8 can also reach d5, but may become a target for Nc3.

WORKED SEQUENCE

3... exd5 4. Nf3 Nf6

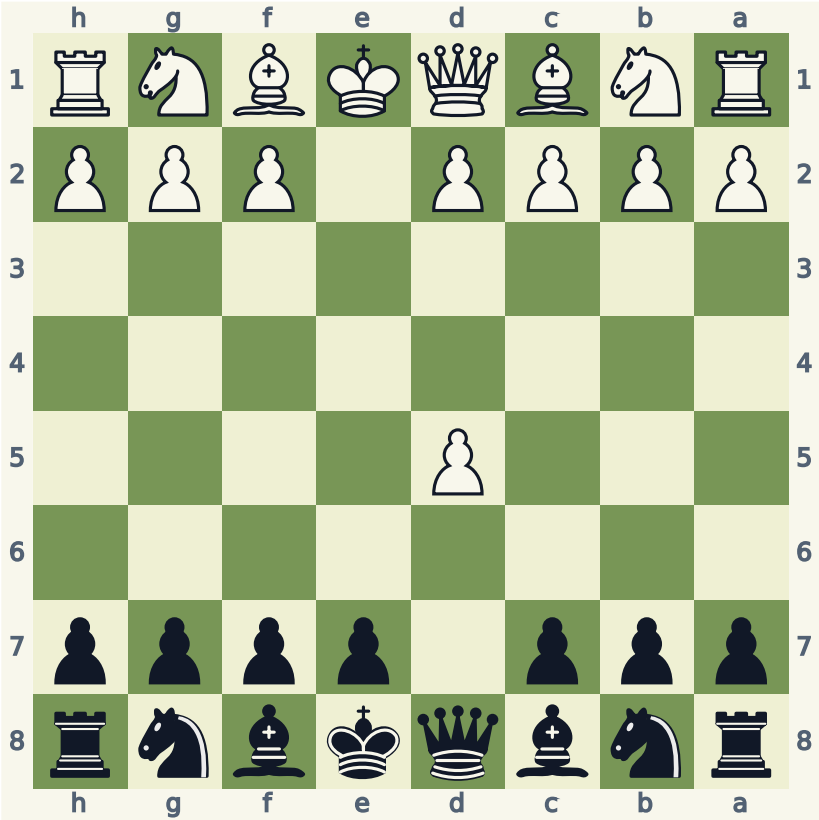
...exd5 restores material and puts a pawn in the center without exposing the queen. White and Black can then develop with Nf3 and ...Nf6. This is a sound, uncomplicated choice in the French Exchange structure.

Compare ...Qxd5 Nc3: White develops a knight while attacking the queen. Black must account for that threat. The queen recapture is legal and does not lose the queen by force; it is less convenient here because the pawn recapture accomplishes the job without that extra target.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / BLACK TO MOVE



- 1. Can Black play ...exd5 in this position? Explain using the pawn's starting square.
- 2. Show a legal immediate recapture and White's developing attack on it.
- 3. Name a safe queen square after that attack.

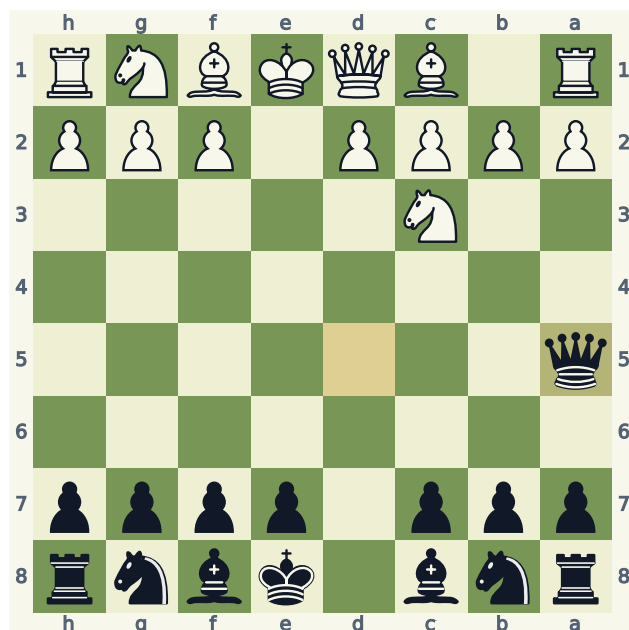
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): rnbqkbnr/ppp1pppp/8/3P4/8/8/PPPP1PPP/RNBQKBNR b KQkq - 0 2

Check your reasoning

2... Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. No. The e-pawn is still on e7, and from there it captures d6 or f6, not d5. You cannot transfer the French recapture to the Scandinavian position.

2. ...Qxd5 regains the pawn. Nc3 develops with an attack on the queen. Black can also choose the different Scandinavian approach ...Nf6; this lesson examines the immediate queen recapture.

3. ...Qa5 is a legal, established retreat. The queen travels d5-c5-b5-a5. It remains active while Black prepares development. The move costs a tempo, but that fact alone does not refute the opening.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

"Never recapture with the queen" is too broad. In another opening the alternative pawn recapture may not exist, and an early queen move may be a normal part of the plan.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

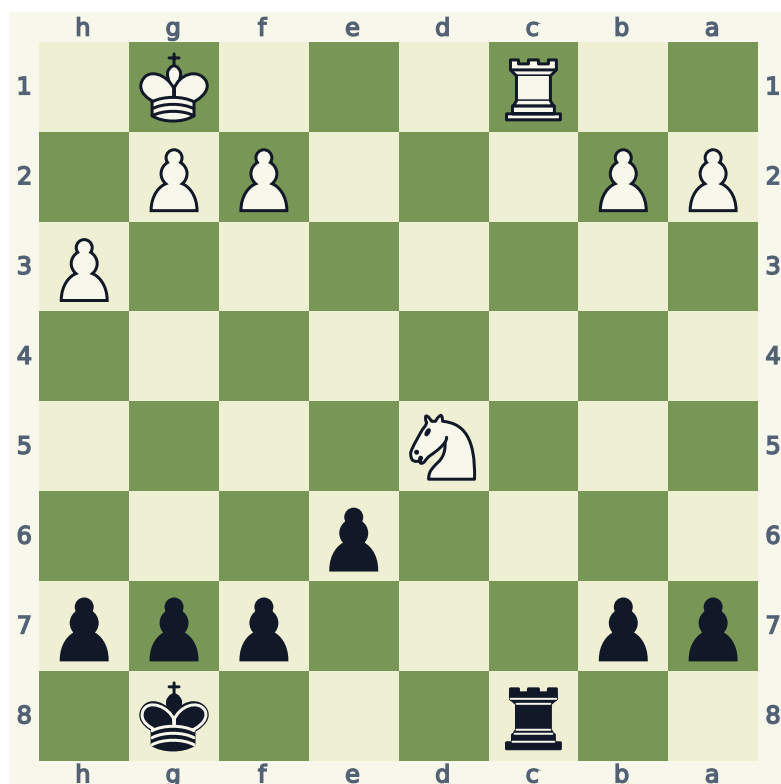
After an exchange, list every legal recapture. Compare material first, king safety second, and the opponent's next developing attack third.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Look for a check before recapturing

A recapture is a candidate, not an obligation. An in-between move can be stronger when it gives check and forces the opponent to answer before recovering material.

MODEL A / BLACK TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. The rooks on c8 and c1 face each other on an otherwise clear file.
2. Black's e6-pawn can capture the knight on d5.
3. White's king can answer a back-rank check by going to h2 because its h-pawn is on h3.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1... Rxc1+ 2. Kh2 exd5

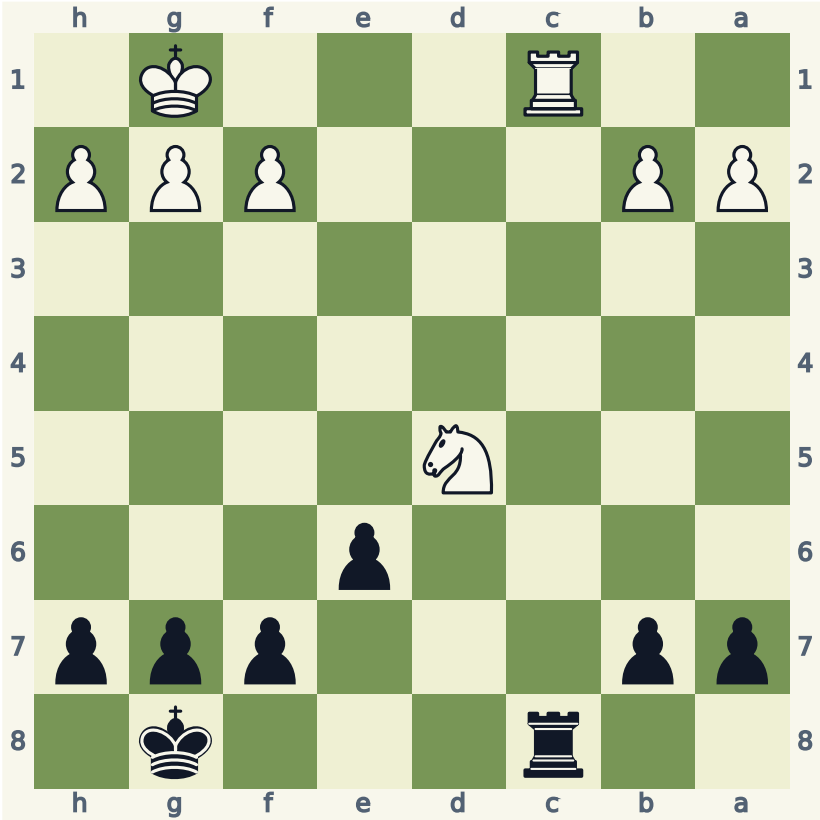
Black first plays ...Rxc1+. White must answer the check and cannot save the knight at the same time. After Kh2, ...exd5 collects the knight as well. Put the check before the pawn capture.

Count the full sequence: Black captures a rook and then a knight while keeping its own rook. Reversing the order is disastrous because White's rook gains access to Black's unprotected back rank. Move order is the entire tactic.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / BLACK TO MOVE



1. Which pawn changed, and which white king escape did that remove?
2. What is Black's strongest forcing move?
3. Should Black plan to take the knight on the next move?

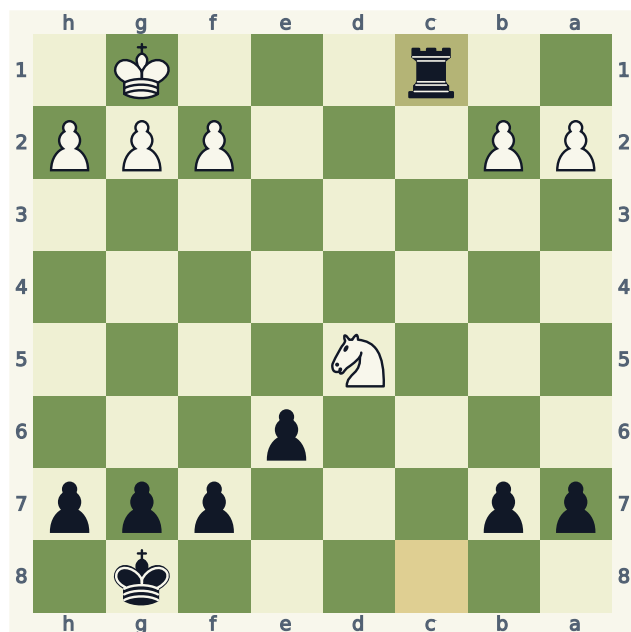
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 2r3k1/pp3ppp/4p3/3N4/8/8/PP3PPP/2R3K1 b - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1... Rxc1#

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. White's h-pawn is now on h2. The king cannot move onto its own pawn, so the h2 escape from Model A has disappeared.

2. ...Rxc1# is immediate checkmate. The rook checks along the first rank, White cannot capture or block, and the king has no safe destination.

3. There is no next move: the game has ended. Capturing the knight is irrelevant. A good calculation reports the earliest decisive result rather than automatically completing a memorized sequence.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

After ...exd5? White has Rxc8#. Black's king is boxed in by its own pawns. Do not assume that recapturing an exposed piece is urgent enough to skip a check scan.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

Before every automatic recapture in a training game, pause for checks on both sides. Save one example where the order of two moves changed the result.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. What are the three kinds of reply to a check?
2. Why is ...exd5 available in the French example but not the Scandinavian?
3. What makes an in-between check especially forcing?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. Capture the checking piece, block a line check, or move the king to a safe square.
2. The French e-pawn is on e6, attacking d5. The Scandinavian e-pawn is still on e7.
3. The opponent must answer the check immediately, which may deny time to save another threatened piece.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.